Midterm Elections

The USA, November 2026



Warm-up

Who would you vote for?



Troy Jackson

- Logger from Allagash, northern Maine
- Former President of the Maine State Senate



Susan Collins

- Grew up in Caribou, northern Maine
- U.S. Senator from Maine since 1997

What do they stand for?

Troy Jackson (Democrat)

- Medicare for All: government health insurance for everyone
- Abolish ICE, the immigration agency he calls "rogue"
- Opposes the war with Iran; would never vote for military aid to Israel
- Protect abortion rights in federal law

Susan Collins (Republican)

- Says she votes against her own party more than any other senator
- Voted against Trump's "One Big Beautiful Bill" (2025)
- Supports abortion rights — but voted to confirm Justice Kavanaugh, who helped overturn *Roe v. Wade*
- Chairs the committee that controls federal spending

Do you still feel confident in your vote?

Most voters are not well informed

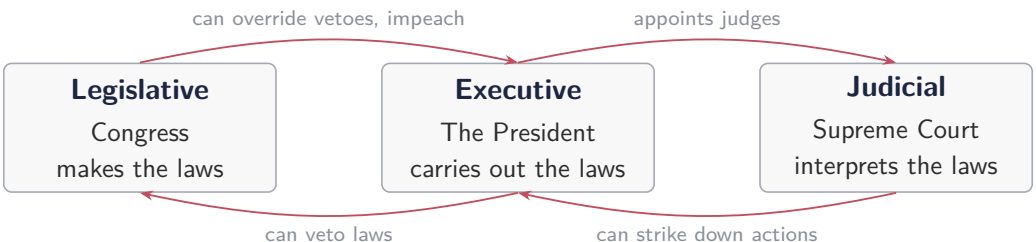
- Only 65% of Americans can name all three branches of government
- Only about half know which party controls each chamber of Congress
- Many voters decide based on party, name recognition, or a single ad

Source: Annenberg Public Policy Center, Civics Surveys (2024, 2026).

What Is a Midterm?

Basic civics: three branches

The U.S. government is divided into three coequal branches in a system of checks and balances.



Text Analysis

James Wilson, signer of the Constitution and one of the first Supreme Court justices, *Lectures on Law* (1791)

> *"The executive as well as the legislative power ought to be restrained. . . . The restraints on the legislative authority, must from its nature, be chiefly internal; that is, they must proceed from some part or division of itself. But the restraints on the executive power are external. These restraints are applied with the greatest certainty, and with greatest efficacy, when the object of restraint is clearly ascertained. This is best done, when one object only, distinguished and responsible, is conspicuously held up to the view and examination of the publick [sic]. . . . "*

Text Analysis

James Wilson, *Lectures on Law* (1791), continued

> *". . . In planning, forming and arranging laws, deliberation is always becoming, and always useful. But in the active scenes of government, there are emergencies, in which the man, as, in other cases, the women [sic], who deliberates is lost. Secrecy may be equally necessary as dispatch. But, can either secrecy or dispatch be expected, when, to every enterprise, mutual communication, mutual consultation, and mutual agreement among men, perhaps of discordant views, of discordant tempers, and of discordant interests, are indispensably necessary? How much time will be consumed!"*

Compare: the USA and Austria

	USA	Austria
Who runs the government?	The President	The Chancellor
How are they chosen?	Elected separately from Congress	Needs a majority in parliament (*Nationalrat*)
Head of state	The President (same person)	The Federal President (mostly ceremonial)
National elections	Every 2 years	Every 5 years

Congress: the legislative branch

Congress has two chambers:

- **House of Representatives**
  - 435 members, 2-year terms
  - Seats divided by population
- **Senate**
  - 100 members, 6-year terms
  - 2 senators per state, no matter the size
  - *Filibuster:* most bills need 60 of 100 votes



The U.S. Capitol, Washington, D.C.

What is a midterm?

- The President serves **four-year** terms
- Midterms are congressional elections halfway through a President's term
  - All 435 House seats and about a third of the Senate
  - 2026: Tuesday, **November 3**

What usually happens?

- Public opinion is "thermostatic": it shifts against the party in power
- In effect, the President's party and positions become more and more unpopular

Think

Given this trend, what would we expect to happen in the midterms?

Buyer's remorse

> *"He tells you one thing and does just the opposite."*

— Trump voter in Iowa, on gas and food prices (MS NOW, 2026)

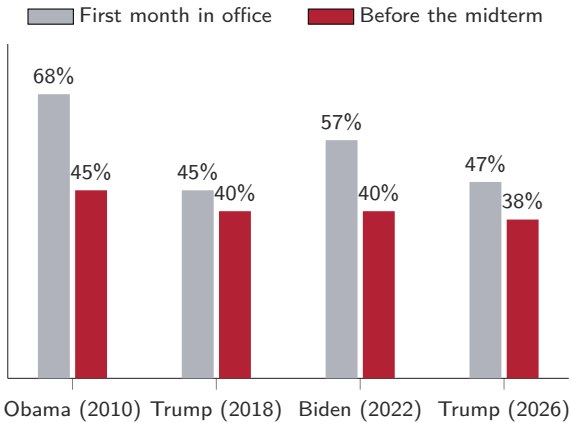
> *"It just seems like everything has gone downhill."*

— Richard, 56, voted Biden in 2020 and Trump in 2024 (NPR focus group, 2026)

> *"I've been so disappointed that I'm just going to go straight and just do Democrat, Democrat, Democrat."*

— Karla, 49, voted Republican in 2024 (NPR focus group, 2026)

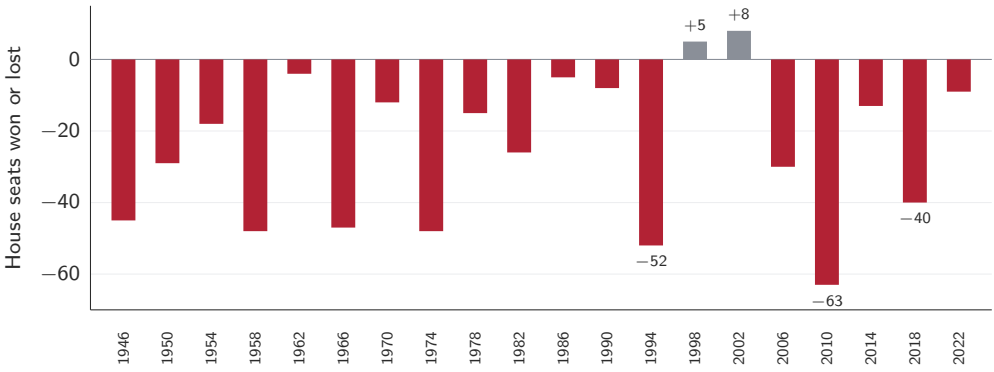
Presidents get less popular



- Every recent President was less popular at the midterm than at the start
- In September, one in five 2024 Trump voters said they regretted their vote

Presidential job approval. Sources: Gallup; 2026 value is the Nov. 3 exit poll (NBC News, CBS News). Regret figure: Navigator Research (Sept. 2026).

The President's party almost always loses seats



The President's party lost House seats in 18 of the 20 midterms from 1946 to 2022. When the President's approval is below 50%, the average loss is 37 seats.

Sources: University of Michigan Center for Political Studies; Gallup.

The 2026 Campaign

What the forecasts said

- Trump was deeply unpopular: about 38% approved (final Reuters/Ipsos poll: 32%)
- Democrats were **heavily favored** to win the House and **favored** to win the Senate

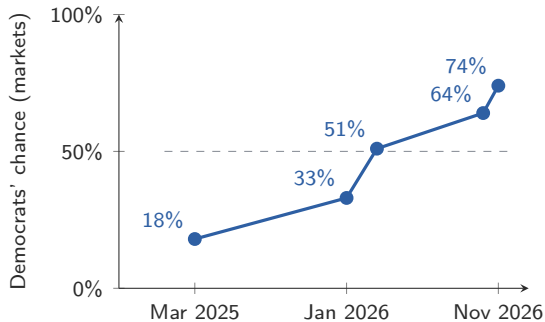
94%	~93%	74%	80%
House	House	Senate	Senate
Markets	Nate Silver	Markets	Nate Silver

Chance that Democrats would win control, on the eve of the election

Markets: Kalshi and Polymarket, Nov. 2. Silver Bulletin Senate: Nov. 2–3; House: October.

Democrats: a real shot at the Senate

- Republicans held the Senate **53–47**
- Democrats needed to gain 4 seats
- In early 2025, this looked almost impossible



Approximate prediction-market prices (Polymarket and Kalshi), as reported by Yahoo News, Polymarket and Quartz.

Democrats: flipping red states?



James Talarico

Texas ▪ vs. Ken Paxton (R)

- Texas hadn't elected a Democrat to the Senate since 1988
- Final polls: Talarico ahead by about 3 points



Mary Peltola

Alaska ▪ vs. Sen. Dan Sullivan (R)

- Alaska hadn't elected a Democrat to the Senate since 2008
- Final polls: very close, Peltola slightly ahead

Polls: Silver Bulletin (Texas), New York Times/Siena (Alaska, 48–46). Photos: Antonioaesparza, CC BY-SA 4.0; U.S. House of Representatives.

But also: Democratic infighting

The Maine Senate race

- **June:** Graham Platner, an oyster farmer and Marine veteran backed by Bernie Sanders, wins the primary over Governor Janet Mills
- **July 10:** Platner drops out after a sexual assault allegation (which he denies) and other scandals: old Reddit posts and a tattoo resembling a Nazi symbol
- **Troy Jackson** had just lost the primary for governor (3rd place)
- **July 25:** The party picks Jackson as the new candidate at a convention
- Mills refused to endorse him; Collins had more money in the bank
- Final polls: a close race, Jackson ahead by about 4 points



Jackson (D)



Collins (R)

Read aloud

Candidate A on Candidate B:

> *"We don't need a celebrity candidate. . . . It didn't work out, so he started the podcast, he wrote the books, and now he's running for Senate."*

Candidate B's answer:

> *"Congresswoman, if you enjoy podcasts about public health, I welcome you to take a listen."*

Surprise: they are in the same party!



Candidate A:
Haley Stevens



Candidate B:
Abdul El-Sayed

- Both are Democrats, from the 2026 Michigan Senate primary
- Moderate vs. progressive
- Stevens and her allies spent about 9 times more on ads
- El-Sayed won, 48.5% to 47.5%
- He went on to face Republican Mike Rogers in November

Quotes: Michigan Senate primary debate, July 27, 2026. Ad spending: AdImpact via CNBC.

How did Republicans respond?

- Facing bad polls, Trump and the Republicans tried to change the rules before November
- **Supporters said:** the new rules would stop non-citizens from voting and prevent fraud
- **Critics said:** non-citizen voting is extremely rare; the real goal was to make voting harder and tilt the election
- Three main strategies:
  1. New voting laws (the SAVE America Act)
  2. Limiting mail-in voting
  3. Redrawing district maps

New voting rules

The SAVE America Act

- Would have required **proof of citizenship** (e.g. a passport) to register and a **photo ID** to vote
- Passed the House in February, 218–213
- Never passed the Senate: not enough votes to beat the filibuster
- Trump demanded that the Senate abolish the filibuster; Republican leaders said they didn't have the votes

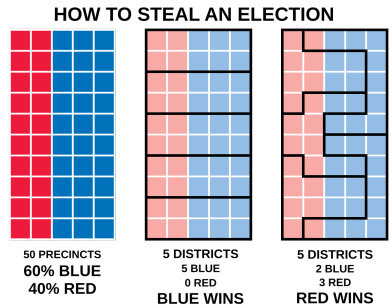
Trump's mail-in voting order

- Signed March 31, 2026
- The Postal Service would have refused to deliver mail ballots to anyone not on a government-approved list
- September: the Supreme Court blocked it for 2026, 7–2
- Mail voting went ahead as usual

Sources: NBC News; Votebeat; The Hill.

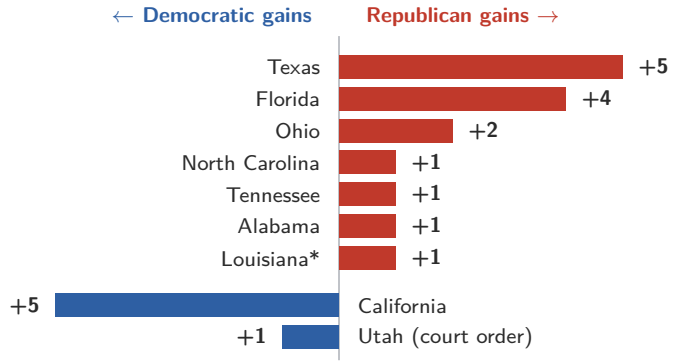
Mid-decade redistricting

- Each state draws its own House districts, normally **once every 10 years**, after the census
- **Gerrymandering:** drawing district lines so that one party wins more seats than its share of votes
- **2025:** Trump pushed Texas to redraw its map in the middle of the decade to create 5 new Republican seats
- California answered with its own Democratic map — and a "map war" began



Same voters, different maps. Diagram: Steve Nass, CC BY-SA 4.0

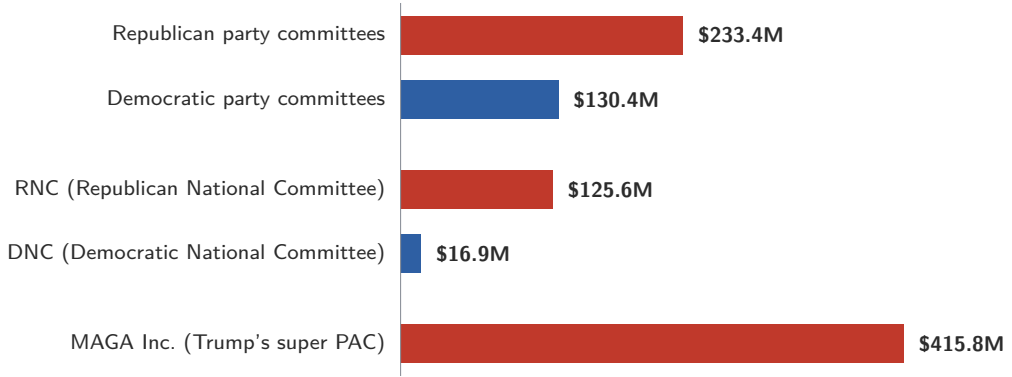
The map war: new seats for 2026



On paper: roughly +9 seats for Republicans. Virginia's Democratic map was struck down by its state court; Indiana Republicans refused to redraw.

Planned seat gains, before the election. *Louisiana's map was challenged in court but stayed in use. Source: Wikipedia, "2025–2026 United States redistricting."

Money: Republicans had far more cash



The DNC was also $17.6 million in debt.

Cash on hand at the end of August 2026. Source: FEC filings via CNBC.

Money: where did it come from, where did it go?

Where it came from

- **Billionaires:** Elon Musk was the biggest donor of 2026; Miriam Adelson gave about $68 million
- **Tech & crypto:** the founders of Andreessen Horowitz gave $115 million; the crypto super PAC Fairshake had over $140 million
- **But:** many Democratic *candidates* raised more from small online donors (Jackson: $20 million+)

Where it went

- Super PACs can spend unlimited money, as long as they don't coordinate with candidates
- Musk gave $158 million to the Senate Leadership Fund, which sent $158 million to Texas to fight Talarico
- Most of it paid for TV and online ads in battleground states

Sources: Washington Post; Forbes; Public Citizen; AP; FEC.

If we have time: the ads

See how the money played out in the Senate battlegrounds:

- **Maine:** Troy Jackson vs. Susan Collins
- **Texas:** James Talarico vs. Ken Paxton
- **Alaska:** Mary Peltola vs. Dan Sullivan
- **Michigan:** Abdul El-Sayed vs. Mike Rogers

The Results

What Maine decided



Troy Jackson (D)



Susan Collins (R)

What Maine decided



Troy Jackson (D)
53.8%

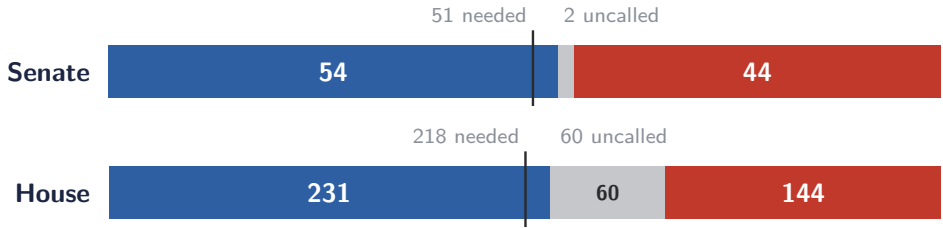


Susan Collins (R)
46.1%

- Collins conceded after almost 30 years in the Senate
- A logger and union member from northern Maine beat one of the best-known senators in the country
- How did our class vote?

Source: NBC News, 86% counted, as of Nov. 4. Unofficial.

Democrats win both chambers



- Democrats flipped 7 Senate seats, and both uncalled seats are Republican-held
- House projection: about 258 Democrats, 177 Republicans, the most Democratic seats since 1993

NBC News, as of Nov. 4; the 54 includes two independents who caucus with Democrats. House estimates: NBC 258, CBS 259. Before the election: Senate 53–47 Republican, House 218–214 Republican.

Seven Senate seats flipped

State	Democrat	Republican
North Carolina	Roy Cooper 58.7	Michael Whatley 39.1
Texas	James Talarico 55.2	Ken Paxton 42.9
Maine	Troy Jackson 53.8	Susan Collins 46.1
South Carolina	Annie Andrews 51.1	Darline Graham 46.7
Kansas	Adam Hamilton 50.9	Roger Marshall 46.1
Iowa	Josh Turek 50.5	Ashley Hinson 46.4
Ohio	Sherrod Brown 50.0	Jon Husted 45.2

- Kansas elected its first Democratic senator since 1932; South Carolina its first since 1998
- No Democratic seat flipped to the Republicans

Source: NBC News, percent of votes counted so far, as of Nov. 4. Unofficial.

Back to our candidates



James Talarico

Texas

Won, 55–43

First Democrat elected to the Senate from Texas since 1988



Abdul El-Sayed

Michigan

Won, 52.5–45.5 over Mike Rogers

He will be the first Muslim U.S. senator



Mary Peltola

Alaska

Too close to call

Source: NBC News, as of Nov. 4. Unofficial.

Still too close to call

Alaska

Sullivan (R) **48.5%**, Peltola (D) **47.7%**, 72% counted

- Many uncounted votes are in rural areas expected to favor Peltola
- If nobody passes 50%, ranked-choice counting takes place on Nov. 18
- A second "Dan Sullivan", a retired teacher, is also on the ballot (1.7%)

Mississippi

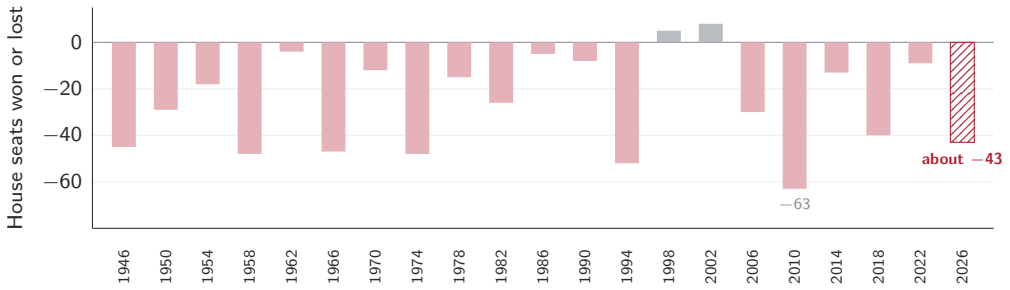
Colom (D) **48.9%**, Hyde-Smith (R) **48.9%**, 96% counted

- Colom led by only 43 votes at one point overnight
- Thousands of affidavit (provisional) ballots remain, which could take days
- No runoff: the candidate with the most votes wins
- A Colom win would be Mississippi's first for a Democrat since 1982

Final Senate range: 54–46 to 56–44, Democrats ahead in every case.

Sources: NBC News; Anchorage Daily News; Magnolia Tribune, as of Nov. 4.

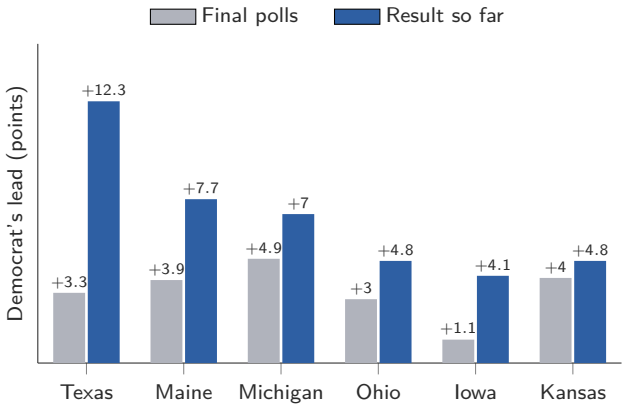
History repeated itself



- Thermostatic public opinion again: the President's party lost ground
- The estimated loss is close to the 37-seat average for unpopular Presidents
- Republicans lost even after redrawing maps in their favor

2026 estimate: NBC News projection (177 Republican seats) compared with 220 won in 2024. Not final.

The forecasts: right direction, too low



- Forecasters and betting markets called both chambers correctly
- Polls underestimated Democrats in every race shown
- A 74–80% chance is not a sure thing: remember 2016

Polls: Silver Bulletin, Nov. 3. Results: NBC News, as of Nov. 4, votes still being counted.

The map war: what actually happened

Republicans planned up to +15 seats in seven states. Instead:

- **Texas:** hoped for a 30–8 delegation and got 24–14. Won only 1 of 5 target seats and lost 2 seats they already held
- **Florida:** targeted Democrats held on in several redrawn seats, including Kathy Castor. Some races are still being counted
- **Missouri:** voters rejected the Republican map in a referendum (Prop A); Rep. Emanuel Cleaver won re-election
- **New word: dummymander.** A gerrymander that spreads your voters too thin, so it backfires in a bad year

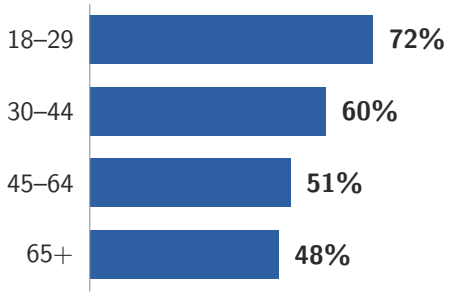
Sources: Texas Tribune; CBS News; KCUR; Mediaite, as of Nov. 4.

Did money decide it?

- The most expensive election cycle ever: about $11.6 billion in political ads
- Texas Senate: the most expensive non-presidential race on record (over $573 million)
- Elon Musk spent at least $474 million, $224 million of it in Texas
- Outside groups spent about **$300M** for Paxton and **$80M** for Talarico. Talarico won by 12
- Michigan too: about **$169M** for Rogers, **$94M** for El-Sayed
- Remember Stevens, who outspent El-Sayed 9 to 1?

Sources: AdImpact via Al Jazeera, The Hill and others (late Oct.); CNBC analysis of campaign finance records (Nov. 4).

Who voted how?



Share voting for the Democratic House candidate, by age

- Women 58–40 for Democrats; men tied 49–49
- Latino voters 62–35 for Democrats, after about 4 in 10 voted Trump in 2024
- Top issues: the economy (39%), the state of democracy (32%), immigration (14%)
- 62% disapproved of Trump

Sources: NBC News Exit Poll (SSRS), Nov. 3; AP Voter Poll (about 80,000 voters). Preliminary.

Governors and ballot measures

Governors

- Democrats flipped 5: Georgia, Iowa, Nevada, Ohio, Texas
- Democrats clinched a majority of governorships for the first time in at least 16 years
- Texas Gov. Greg Abbott lost to Gina Hinojosa, 52.9–45.6
- Keisha Lance Bottoms (Georgia): first Black woman elected governor in U.S. history
- Kansas and Alaska: still uncalled

Ballot measures: voters didn't simply follow party lines

- **Abortion rights** won in Virginia and Nevada; Missouri rejected a repeal
- But Idaho rejected an abortion-rights measure
- **Voter ID** passed in Ohio, North Carolina and Nevada, but failed in California
- **Redistricting:** Maryland approved an amendment that could allow a new map for 2028

Sources: NBC News; France 24/AFP; Stateline, as of Nov. 4.

Why did it happen?

Democrats say

- A "change election" (Hakeem Jeffries)
- Voters want action on costs, health care and accountability

Republicans say

- The President's party usually loses seats at the midterm (Mike Johnson)
- "I wasn't on the Ballot" (Trump); a White House official blamed the quality of candidates

What the exit polls show

- 6 in 10 said Trump was a factor in their vote
- Voters disliked both parties: Democrats net -6, Republicans net -18

Sources: CBS News; NBC News; RTÉ/AFP; Al Jazeera, Nov. 4.

What happens next?

- Trump stays President until January 2029: midterms cannot remove him
- The new Congress starts in January 2027. Until then, Republicans keep control (a "lame duck" Congress)
- Expected leaders: Hakeem Jeffries, first Black **Speaker of the House**; Chuck Schumer, **Senate Majority Leader**
- Democrats can investigate, and can block Trump's nominees and laws
- But Trump can veto bills, and overriding him takes two-thirds of each chamber
- The filibuster still means most bills need 60 Senate votes
- Trump says he accepts the results: "absolutely willing to accept" them

Sources: NBC News; CBS News; The Hill; New York Times via RTÉ/AFP, Nov. 4.